U.S. Government Publishing Office
Publications Help Desk

Frequently Asked Questions

Short answers to the questions the Publications Help Desk receives most often

Field	Value
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Training sample. All names, contact details, prices, timelines, and procedures in this document are fictional and were created for a Microsoft Copilot Studio demonstration. They do not represent actual GPO policy.

Document Control

This section records the revision history and the approval chain for this document. Changes to any procedural step, time target, fee, or contact require a new version number and approval by the document owner.

Version	Date	Author	Summary of change
4.0	February 20, 2025	M. Grant	Rebuilt around PHD Service Portal intake
5.0	March 9, 2026	M. Grant	Updated proof timing to 2 business days; added digital publishing section
5.2	June 16, 2026	T. Lindqvist	Expanded accessibility answers
6.0	October 1, 2026	M. Grant	Aligned fees with Fee Schedule v4.2; added billing and style sections

How to Use This Document

Each answer below is deliberately short. Where a fuller explanation exists, the answer names the document that holds it. Questions are grouped by topic. If your question is not here, contact the Publications Help Desk through the PHD Service Portal, by email at pubhelpdesk@gpo.gov, or by telephone at (202) 555-0147 during staffed hours.

1. Getting Started

1.1 Who can submit a publishing request?

Designated agency publishing liaisons and GPO internal customers with a cost center. Liaisons are designated in writing by the agency publishing officer and receive a PHD Service Portal account once the designation is on file. Members of the public cannot submit requests.

1.2 How do I become a designated liaison?

Ask your agency publishing officer to send a designation letter or email to pubhelpdesk@gpo.gov naming you, your agency, your telephone number, and the agency billing codes you are authorized to use. The help desk creates your portal account within 3 business days and sends you the New Liaison Onboarding Briefing (GPO-PHD-007).

1.3 What are the help desk hours?

Monday through Friday, 7:30 a.m. to 5:00 p.m. Eastern Time, excluding Federal holidays. Requests submitted outside those hours are acknowledged on the next business day. There is no weekend or after-hours coverage; see the Service Level Agreement and Escalation Matrix (GPO-PHD-005) for the Priority 1 after-hours procedure.

1.4 What is the difference between a ticket and a PSR?

A ticket (PHD-YYYY-NNNNNN) is the help desk record for any request or question. A Publishing Service Request, or PSR (PSR-YY-NNNNN), is the form that starts a publishing job. Submitting a PSR automatically creates a linked ticket. Quote the ticket number when you follow up on anything.

1.5 Where is the PHD Service Portal?

It is linked from the GPO intranet home page under Customer Services. Agency liaisons receive a direct link in their onboarding email. The portal requires your Government network credentials.

2. Submitting a Publishing Service Request

2.1 What do I need before I start a PSR?

An active portal account, the agency billing code you are authorized to use, a print ready or digital ready file, a required by date with a reason, and a completed Section 508 checklist for any file that will be released electronically. The full prerequisite list is in the Publishing Service Request Submission Procedure (GPO-PHD-002), Section 2.

2.2 What fields are required on the PSR?

Requester details, publication title, request type (new, revision, or reprint), product family and type, trim size, page count, paper stock, ink, binding and finishing, quantity, delivery address, required by date, service level, Section 508 attestation, FDLP eligibility, electronic release choice, agency billing code, and at least one attachment. Appendix A of GPO-PHD-002 lists every field.

2.3 What happens after I submit?

The help desk reviews the PSR for completeness within 1 business day. If it is complete, it goes to Production Planning, which issues a cost estimate within 2 business days. You approve the estimate, receive a PDF proof within 2 business days, approve the proof, and production begins on the next business day.

2.4 Why was my PSR returned?

Every return carries one or more reason codes, RC-01 through RC-12, that explain what was missing or wrong and how to fix it. The most common are RC-01 (required field blank), RC-06 (fonts not embedded), and RC-08 (Section 508 attestation missing). Correct the issue and resubmit; the completeness review restarts.

2.5 Can I submit native files instead of PDF?

Only when the PSR includes design or typesetting services. For all other jobs, submit a print ready PDF that meets the requirements in GPO-PHD-002, Section 3.

2.6 What is the maximum attachment size?

100 MB per file in the portal. For larger files, note the size in the PSR comments and the help desk will arrange a transfer.

2.7 How should I name my files?

Use the pattern AGENCYCODE_ShortTitle_vN.pdf, for example DOI_TrailGuide2026_v3.pdf. Consistent names make proofs and revisions easier to track.

3. Turnaround and Service Levels

3.1 How long does a standard job take?

Standard turnaround is 10 business days from proof approval for most products, 7 business days for cards, postcards, and newsletters, 5 business days for digital only publications, and 12 to 15 business days for specialty products such as labels, tabs, and binders. The Turnaround Matrix in the Job Catalog and Fee Schedule (GPO-PHD-006) is the authoritative list.

3.2 When does the turnaround clock start?

On the business day after you approve the final proof in the portal. It does not start at PSR submission. Plan for roughly 17 to 20 business days from submission to delivery for a typical booklet on standard service.

3.3 What is rush service and what does it cost?

Rush service is a 2 business day turnaround for rush eligible products, with a surcharge of 35 percent on the unit price and setup fee. Digital only files under 100 pages can be released the next business day. Rush must be approved by Production Planning based on capacity; the decision appears on your cost estimate.

3.4 Which products are not rush eligible?

Labels and decals, tabs and dividers, binders and kits, and carbonless forms, because they depend on vendor or die cutting lead times. Rush booklets are limited to 5,000 units and rush perfect bound reports to 250 pages.

3.5 What is priority service?

A 5 business day turnaround with a 15 percent surcharge on the unit price and setup fee. It is available for all products except labels, tabs, and binders.

3.6 Is same day service available?

No. The fastest service level is rush, at 2 business days, or next business day for small digital only files.

3.7 Do business days include holidays?

No. Business days are Monday through Friday, excluding Federal holidays.

4. Cost Estimates, Fees, and Billing

4.1 How do I find out what a job will cost?

Look up the product in the Job Catalog (GPO-PHD-006) for the unit price at your quantity break and the setup fee, then add any surcharge or ordered services from the Fee Schedule sheet. The help desk can walk you through the lookup. The binding price is the cost estimate that Production Planning issues for your PSR.

4.2 How long is a cost estimate valid?

30 calendar days. After that the PSR is closed as Expired and must be resubmitted.

4.3 Is delivery included?

Standard ground delivery to one address within the continental United States is included. Each additional address is 18 dollars. Expedited 2 business day delivery is carrier cost plus 25 dollars, and overseas or non contiguous delivery is carrier cost plus 40 dollars.

4.4 What does an extra proof round cost?

The first PDF proof and one revision round are included. Each additional revision round is 75 dollars. A physical press proof for offset jobs is 185 dollars and adds 2 business days.

4.5 What does it cost to cancel?

Before proof approval, nothing, except for design, typesetting, or editorial hours already performed. After proof approval, the actual cost of work performed, including materials and scheduled press time.

4.6 Can the help desk give me a discount?

No. Prices come from the catalog and the cost estimate. The help desk does not negotiate prices or offer discounts. The only price reductions are the published quantity breaks and the setup fee waiver for reprints with no changes within 12 months.

4.7 How is my agency billed?

Through the agency billing code you enter on the PSR. The approved cost estimate is the document of record; there is no separate purchase order step for interagency work. Invoices reflect the quantity delivered, within the 5 percent overrun or underrun allowance.

4.8 What is the minimum order?

50 units for offset printing. Digital printing has no minimum.

5. Proofs, Changes, and Delivery

5.1 How do I approve a proof?

In the portal, on the PSR. Approvals by email or telephone are not accepted because they cannot be tied to a specific proof version. Proof approval starts the turnaround clock.

5.2 What if I need to change the specifications after approving the estimate?

That is a change order. Add a comment on the PSR. Production Planning issues a revised estimate that includes the 125 dollar change order fee plus rework, a new proof is produced, and the turnaround clock restarts at the new proof approval.

5.3 My delivery is short or damaged. What do I do?

Report it through the portal within 5 business days of receipt, with photographs if possible. Production Planning arranges replacement, credit, or reprint.

5.4 Can I get tracking information?

Yes. The carrier tracking number is recorded on the PSR when the job ships and the status changes to Shipped.

5.5 How do I reorder something we printed last year?

Submit a new PSR, select Reprint, and enter the prior PSR number. If nothing has changed and the original job was within the last 12 months, the setup fee is waived. Any change, including a new date, makes it a revision at full setup.

6. Accessibility

6.1 Do I have to make my publication accessible?

Yes, if it will be released electronically in any form. Section 508 requires it, and the PSR requires either an attestation that the file passes the Section 508 Accessibility Checklist for Publications (GPO-PHD-003) or a remediation service request.

6.2 What are the most common accessibility failures?

Untagged PDFs, alternative text that says only image or photo, headings styled with bold text instead of heading styles, tables built with tabs, low contrast text, and document titles that show the file name. GPO-PHD-003, Section 11, lists fixes for each.

6.3 What contrast ratio is required?

At least 4.5 to 1 for normal text and 3 to 1 for large text, measured against the immediate background, including tinted boxes and photographs.

6.4 When are bookmarks required?

For any document of more than 20 pages, as a house rule. Bookmarks should map to the major headings.

6.5 What does remediation cost and how long does it take?

Remediation of a tagged PDF is 4 dollars and 50 cents per page, and a written accessibility conformance report is 210 dollars per document. Standard turnaround is 5 business days for documents up to 100 pages, and it runs in parallel with print production.

6.6 Can print only products skip the checklist?

Yes, if the product will never exist electronically. The liaison makes that determination by selecting Not applicable in Section F of the PSR and is accountable for it.

7. Digital Publishing and Distribution

7.1 What formats are accepted for digital only publications?

Tagged PDF, PDF/A, EPUB, and HTML packages. The Digital Publishing Intake coordinator validates document properties, bookmarks for documents over 20 pages, and tag structure. Files that fail validation are returned with reason code RC-09.

7.2 What is the digital publishing intake fee?

95 dollars per file up to 100 pages, and 160 dollars per file over 100 pages. The fee includes metadata review and, for longer files, bookmark verification.

7.3 How do I request depository library distribution?

Mark the publication as FDLP eligible in Section G of the PSR. The help desk coordinates depository distribution with the responsible GPO unit after production. You do not need to contact that unit yourself.

7.4 Can I have both a printed edition and an electronic release?

Yes. Select the print product in Section C and request electronic release in Section G. The electronic file still needs the Section 508 attestation.

8. Style and Editorial

8.1 Which style guide applies?

The GPO Style Manual governs. The Style Quick Reference (GPO-PHD-008) summarizes the conventions that come up most often in PHD produced documents. Where the two differ, the GPO Style Manual controls.

8.2 Can the help desk proofread my document?

The help desk can answer specific style questions. Proofreading and style conformance review are ordered editorial services at 88 dollars per hour, estimated in 15 minute increments, and are requested on the PSR.

8.3 Who do I contact with a style question the quick reference does not answer?

Submit a ticket in the Style and editorial category. The Editorial Standards Lead, Harold Bemis, responds to those tickets.

9. Priorities and Escalation

9.1 How is the priority of my ticket decided?

By business impact. P1 means a Congressional, statutory, or public commitment date is at risk or a job in production has stopped; P2 means a job is blocked; P3 is routine; P4 is informational. The help desk assigns priority, and you may ask for a review.

9.2 How quickly will someone respond?

P1 within 30 minutes during staffed hours, P2 within 2 business hours, P3 within 4 business hours, and P4 within 1 business day. Resolution targets are 4 business hours, 1 business day, 3 business days, and 5 business days respectively.

9.3 How do I escalate?

Ask your specialist to escalate, or contact the Tier 2 escalation point, Devin Okafor, Production Planning Lead, when a ticket has missed its first response target. Tier 3 is Priya Venkataraman, Deputy Director, Customer Services. Full paths and after-hours steps are in GPO-PHD-005.

9.4 What should I do with a Priority 1 situation after hours?

Call the after-hours production line listed in GPO-PHD-005 and quote your PSR number. Then submit a ticket in the portal so the help desk picks it up at 7:30 a.m.

10. Information Handling

10.1 Can I include personal information in a PSR?

Only business contact details. Do not include Social Security numbers, dates of birth, personal home addresses, or financial account numbers. They are never needed and will be removed.

10.2 Can I submit CUI or classified material?

No. The portal and mailbox are for unclassified, non CUI content only. CUI is coordinated by telephone with Production Planning through the agency's designated CUI channel. Classified material is never accepted by the help desk.

10.3 Will the help desk discuss my unreleased publication with others?

No. Help desk staff discuss the content, title, and timing of an unreleased publication only with the designated liaison on that PSR.

11. Mail Fulfillment, Storage, and Distribution

11.1 Can PHD mail my publication for me?

Yes. Mail fulfillment is an ordered service. Addressing is 6 cents per piece from an agency supplied list, machine inserting is 9 cents per piece per insert, and list processing (deduplication and USPS address standardization) is 45 dollars per list. Attach the mailing list to the PSR and select mail fulfillment in Section D.

11.2 What format should a mailing list be in?

A spreadsheet with one address per row and separate columns for name, organization, address lines, city, state, and ZIP code. Lists are processed through USPS address standardization before use, and the standardized count is what is billed.

11.3 Can PHD store finished inventory for us?

Yes. Warehouse storage is free for the first 90 days after delivery and 42 cents per carton per month after that, billed quarterly. On demand pick and pack shipments are 6 dollars and 80 cents per shipment plus carrier charges.

11.4 How do I request a shipment from stored inventory?

Submit a ticket in the Service question category with the original PSR number, the quantity, and the delivery address. Pick and pack shipments leave within 2 business days.

11.5 Can we split delivery between several addresses?

Yes. List each address and the quantity for it in Section D of the PSR. The first address is included; each additional address is 18 dollars, which covers cartons and labeling.

12. Paper, Ink, and Environmental Choices

12.1 What paper stocks are available?

Thirty standard stocks, listed with codes, basis weights, recycled content, and typical uses in the Paper Stock Reference sheet of GPO-PHD-006. Enter the stock code on the PSR. Nonstandard stocks are quoted as Specialty.

12.2 Which stocks have recycled content?

Uncoated text stocks PS-04 and PS-28 and newsprint PS-21 are 100 percent recycled content. Most uncoated stocks contain 30 percent recycled content, and most coated stocks contain 10 percent. The Paper Stock Reference sheet lists the percentage for every stock.

12.3 Can I print in a Pantone spot color?

Yes. Select an ink option that includes a PMS color and name the Pantone number in the PSR comments. Files must define the spot color as a named swatch, not as a CMYK approximation.

12.4 What ink coverage limit applies?

Total ink coverage should not exceed 300 percent on coated stock or 280 percent on uncoated stock. Higher coverage causes drying and offsetting problems and is flagged on the proof.

13. Portal Access and Troubleshooting

13.1 I cannot sign in to the PHD Service Portal. What do I do?

Confirm you are on the Government network or VPN and that your liaison designation is current. If you still cannot sign in, email pubhelpdesk@gpo.gov from your Government address with your name and agency; the help desk resets access within 1 business day.

13.2 My attachment fails to upload.

Check that the file is under 100 MB and that the file name has no special characters other than underscores. If the file is larger than 100 MB, note the size in the PSR comments and the help desk will arrange a transfer.

13.3 Can someone else approve a proof if I am out of the office?

Yes, if you named a secondary contact in Section A of the PSR and that person is also a designated liaison. Add a secondary contact on every PSR; jobs stall most often because the only approver is unavailable.

13.4 How do I change the liaisons for my agency?

Your agency publishing officer sends an updated designation to pubhelpdesk@gpo.gov. Accounts for removed liaisons are disabled the same business day; new accounts are created within 3 business days.

13.5 Can I see all of my agency's open PSRs?

Yes. The portal home page lists every open PSR and ticket for your agency billing codes, with status, next action, and the specialist assigned.

14. Glossary of Status Values

Status	Meaning	Who acts next
Submitted	PSR received; awaiting completeness review	Help desk
Returned	PSR failed completeness review; reason codes attached	Liaison
In Planning	Production Planning is preparing the cost estimate	Production Planning
Estimate Issued	Cost estimate available for approval; valid 30 calendar days	Liaison
Expired	Estimate not approved within 30 calendar days; resubmit if still needed	Liaison
Proof Issued	Proof available for review	Liaison
Revision Requested	Corrections received; new proof in preparation	Production Planning
Proof Approved	Final proof approved; turnaround clock starts next business day	Production
In Production	Job is on press or in finishing	Production
Shipped	Job has left the building; tracking number recorded	Liaison (inspect on receipt)
Released	Digital only publication released electronically	Liaison
Closed	Job complete and invoiced	None
Cancelled	PSR cancelled by the liaison; closing statement issued if charges apply	None

15. Quick Reference Card

Topic	Answer
Hours	Monday to Friday, 7:30 a.m. to 5:00 p.m. Eastern, excluding Federal holidays
Email	pubhelpdesk@gpo.gov
Telephone	(202) 555-0147
Completeness review	1 business day
Cost estimate	2 business days; valid 30 calendar days
First proof	2 business days after estimate approval; one revision round included; 75 dollars per additional round
Standard turnaround	10 business days from proof approval (see Turnaround Matrix for exceptions)
Priority	5 business days; 15 percent surcharge
Rush	2 business days; 35 percent surcharge; rush eligible products only
Offset minimum	50 units; digital has no minimum
Change order	125 dollars plus rework; clock restarts
Delivery	Ground to one address included; 18 dollars per additional address

Topic	Answer
Damage or shortage	Report within 5 business days
Bookmarks	Required over 20 pages
Contrast	4.5 to 1 normal text; 3 to 1 large text
Remediation	4.50 dollars per page; report 210 dollars